"Congress is pushing Muslim League agenda and Left propaganda"

BJP national president **JAGAT PRAKASH NADDA** is confident his party and its allies are on track to breach the 400-mark. In an exclusive interview with Group Editorial Director **RAJ CHENGAPPA** and Deputy Editor **ANILESH S. MAHAJAN**, he says the BJP had been preparing for the polls two years in advance, while the opponents have come underprepared and are not even showing the resolve to fight. Edited excerpts

Q. Compared to 2014 and 2019, what is different this election?

Every election changes with time, and from state to state. In 2014, the vote was for change. Voters were disgusted, disgruntled and there was a lot of negativity. The alternative was Prime Minister [Narendra] Modi. The voters supported us with a huge margin. In 2019, they saw that PM Modi had performed better than their expectations and hence voted him to power again. In 2024, it has become a belief that the country is secure under the leadership of the prime minister, it is developing and there is a vision of a developed India under him. The difference I find is that last time, the Opposition was talking about issues, they still had something, some substance. They were fighting a *ladai*. But this time, they are just shattered and scattered. They are pretending to fight, but, inside, they have all accepted defeat. For example, last time, they gave us a fight in UP. The Opposition had a formidable composition and they fought tooth and nail. This time, they just gave up. They are losing even (their pocket boroughs) Rae Bareli, Kannauj and Mainpuri. And the issues they were picking up, the public has already rejected them. I have been saying for more than two years that if you have to do the politics of opposition, then you have to think out of the box and work hard. If you don't, that's not our fault.

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Q. What are the key issues this election?

First of all, the voters have already made up their minds. The Opposition is mistaken if they think campaigning will change anything. The key issues for us are: development, providing momentum to that development; add speed, scale and skill. Above all, mainstreaming and empowerment are our top priorities—empowerment of women, empowerment of youth, empowerment of marginal sections of the society, empowerment of farmers, empowerment of Dalits, empowerment of tribals. With this, Bharat will grow.

Q. Your rivals are raking up the issue of inequality in society. Rahul Gandhi is talking of redistribution of wealth, and of caste census. They are also targeting the *labharthi varg* (beneficiary class) that PM Modi has created by offering freebies of their own.

Kuchh nahin hai. The Congress and Rahul Gandhi are trying to make superficial interventions. They cannot even understand the problem. PM Modi's schemes, on the other hand, have left a deep impression on the common man. They know that these schemes are really helping them to come into the mainstream and elevate the quality of their life. People are not even interested in the alternatives to these programmes. Sam Pitroda's explanations exposed them (the Congress); the rest, we